

SIGHTSEEING

Do your own sightseeing at your own pace, using local buses, trains, and taxis. Let cabdrivers rip you off for a dollar or two. It's better than spending \$20 each to wait in line for a two-hour city tour.

Avoid renting a car in a foreign country. Foreigners design their cities for people rather than cars. Rent a car and you incur expense and waste time doing paperwork. Better to take a plane, train, or bus from city to city. Once you arrive at your destination, walk or take cabs or local buses. You'll have a more pleasant trip. Rental cars are for Americans who don't know any better.

CHECK-IN

Checking in at airports, train stations, bus stations, and hotels can test the patience of the most unhurried traveler. The Bible's Job himself might have lost his cool trying to get in and out of O'Hare in a snowstorm. Give yourself a break by assigning check-in tasks to one spouse or the other.

When Vicki and I arrive at an airport or bus station, I put her and the bags in the coffeeshop. I check in and inquire about departure gates and the like. She never questions the seats I choose or other details I decide on. When we arrive at our next destination, it's Vicki's turn. She deposits me and the bags in a park, bar, or café. She then heads off and chooses a hotel. I never second-guess her choice.

The system means that, if there's a line, only one of us has to wait in it. We avoid silly disputes over inconsequential details. And after doing this on several trips we began to notice a side benefit. We started getting better prices on hotel rooms. Remember that room prices are negotiable in many parts of the world, and all hotels have some rooms that are cheaper than others. We believe we get better rates because the front-desk clerks see Vicki walk in without bags. They